

'Typesetting'

Presentations with Beamer

Do you use LaTeX for your document processing requirements? Then why switch to any other application when you need to create presentations? Try Beamer instead.



Beamer (latex-beamer.sourceforge.net) is a LaTeX class for making presentation slides. In LaTeX parlance, it's just another Document Class.

Why would you want to hack LaTeX to create slides? Hasn't OpenOffice.org, or worse, a certain Microsoft PowerPoint, already won that battle?

You shouldn't even attempt to use Beamer if you have no idea what LaTeX is. However, if you already use LaTeX—chances are you swear by it—then Beamer is for you. With Beamer, you can create slides for *that* upcoming talk without compromising on eye candy, and with the comfort levels of your favourite document preparation system.

As an aside, explore and learn LaTeX. If you are a student, you will create better-looking project reports; and if you are a writer, you will create more professional looking articles, manuals and books. The *Resources* section at the end will have some links to learn more about LaTeX. To make the best use of the rest of this article, I shall assume an intermediate knowledge of LaTeX.

Installation

The easiest way to install LaTeX Beamer is to use the package manager on your Linux distribution. On Debian and Ubuntu, the package is named *latex-beamer*. Do an *apt-get* install:

```
# apt-get install latex-beamer
```

You will see that some more packages that provide extra LaTeX classes need to be installed. Prominent among these are *latex-xcolor* and *pgf*. Hit a *y* for the installation of the packages to start. You should have the Beamer LaTeX installation in `/usr/share/texmf/tex/latex/beamer/`. (Note that if you do not have LaTeX installed, it might ask you to install more packages.)

There is, of course, the option of installing LaTeX Beamer user guide shows you how to do it.

Now that we are done with the installation, let us create our first presentation with LaTeX Beamer. In the rest of this article, I shall assume that we have used the package manager to install the Beamer LaTeX class. If you have installed it manually, it will just need a little bit of correlation between the article details and the source code.

Simple presentations

Before we create our own presentation, let us compile one of the shipped examples. Copy the *beamerexample-conference-talk.tex* files from `/usr/share/doc/latex-beamer/examples/a-conference-talk` to a sub-directory under your home, say `~/beamer/examples`. Now, compile the *.tex* file using *latex*:

```
$ latex beamerexample-conference-talk.tex ...
./beamerexample-conference-talk.toc [2] [3] [4] [5] [6] [7] [8] [9] [10]
[11] [12] [13] [14] [15] [16] [17] [18] [19] [20] [21] [22] [23] [24] [25]
[26] [27] [28] [29] [30] [31] (./beamerexample-conference-talk.aux)
Output written on beamerexample-conference-talk.dvi (31 pages, 763500
bytes).
Transcript written on beamerexample-conference-talk.log
```

If you see some errors reported, a fix is needed somewhere. We should have the presentation ready in the *.dvi* file. Now, use the *dvipdf* utility to convert it into a PDF file and open it using a PDF reader, such as Evince. Figure 1 is a screenshot of the first slide.

Impressed? I am. Let's continue getting impressed.

Diving in, open the *.tex* file in a LaTeX editor of your choice. VIM-LaTeX (vim-latex.sourceforge.net) brings